

CITIES



LESS THAN 200 YEARS AGO most people lived in villages. Today, around one-half of the world's population lives in cities. During the 19th century, towns and cities expanded as people moved away from rural areas to work in new industries. Cities have continued to grow, but haphazardly, in contrast to the carefully-planned cities of the ancient world.

Modern cities

The world's cities have grown rapidly in modern times but inadequate planning has contributed to poor living conditions and poverty in many urban centres. Poor areas, wealthy neighbourhoods, and areas dominated by one particular ethnic group are all features of city life. Most cities offer many people a wide choice of jobs, houses, and recreational facilities.

Gardens, parks, and squares give people the chance to escape the bustle of city streets.

Entertainment is a feature of most cities. Cities are usually cultural centres with theatres, museums, galleries, and music venues, such as Sydney's striking Opera House.

Residential

There are different residential areas in cities. Older houses and flats are close to the city centre, while modern developments extend outwards, clustering around railway lines and major roads.

Business is always located close to the heart of the city. Nowadays, the business area is usually dominated by tall office blocks.



Sydney, Australia

Villages

A traditional village is a small, rural settlement, often by a stream or river. In most parts of the world, people still live and work in villages, farming the surrounding countryside, and trading with nearby settlements.



Maasai village, Kenya

Many of the Maasai people live in groups of thatched, mud houses surrounding a central cattle enclosure.



Stilt village, Sumatra

In many Southeast Asian villages, houses are raised on stilts to keep out unwanted animals, like snakes.



Gold rush town

Towns grew around 19th century gold mines. Abandoned as the gold ran out, some still stand as "ghost towns".

Timeline

8000 BC Strong walls and a stone tower are built at Jericho.

3500 BC City-states such as Ur, develop in Mesopotamia (modern-day Iraq).

5th century BC Greeks plan and build the elegant city of Athens.

1st century BC The Roman Empire expands, and new European cities are built.

12th century AD Stone walls, such as those at Carcassonne, France, are built to protect medieval towns and cities.



1421 Construction starts on Forbidden City, Beijing, China.

15th century Renaissance architects lay out classical cities, such as Florence and Siena in Italy.



19th century Industrialization stimulates growth of towns and cities in Europe and America.

Siena, Italy

1950s Brasilia designed and constructed as new capital of Brazil.

1990s Skyscrapers dominate most city skylines.



Forbidden City

The Forbidden City in Beijing, China, was built in the 15th century. Only the emperor, his family, and his officials were allowed in.



Çatal Hüyük

Walls made of mud
Hole in roof instead of door
Early cities had no streets.

First cities

Settlements in western Asia, such as Jericho (Israel), Çatal Hüyük (Turkey), and Ur (Iraq), started to expand around 4000 BC. At this time, craftworkers began to trade goods outside their local areas, creating new wealth that was used to build palaces, large temples, and strong, defensive walls. These towns grew in importance and emerged as the first cities.



New York

The city of New York in the USA contains some of the world's tallest skyscraper office blocks. It also has large apartment buildings, low-rise commercial sites (some of which have been converted into homes called lofts), tall, 19th-century brownstone (a type of sandstone) houses, and smaller, modern houses. Steps lead to underground trains and shops.